Tech Harvest · Stage 1: Ideation & Research · Session 3

MVP & Prototype Planning

From a well-understood problem to a solution worth building, and a plan to test it

- Value proposition
- User journey
- MVP scope
- Initial feasibility
- Prototype plan
- Roadmap

Welcome

Mhd Tarek Almalek

Tech entrepreneur · Digital transformation advisor · AI specialist

- Builds products
- Advises on digital transformation
- Works hands-on with AI
- Runs IXCoders and Tamkeen

In 2026, building software got cheap. Building the wrong thing is now the expensive mistake.

That's why we plan before we build. Judgment and evidence are the edge.

Where we are

Session 3: from a clear problem to a planned solution

Sessions 1–2
The problem and its users — Done

→

Session 3 · Today
MVP & prototype planning — Now

→

Stage 1 checkpoint
Outputs reviewed — Next

Stage 1 outputs (participant handbook)

Problem definition	From sessions 1–2. We restate it as the user's job (Module 1) — Sharpen today
Stakeholders & personas	From sessions 1–2. Journey (Module 2) and prototype test (Module 5) — Use today
Value Proposition Canvas	Fit between their jobs, pains and gains and your solution (Module 1) — Build today
Initial feasibility	Can we build it, run it, afford it, and is it allowed? (Module 4) — Build today

Checkpoint looks at: understanding of the problem · clarity of the solution · potential for technical development

Today

Optional case study: Dabberli

3 hours 45 minutes, half of it hands-on

We plan today. Stage 2 (Oct 29 – Nov 28) builds what we plan.

0:00	Opening		10 min
0:10	1 · From problem to value proposition	Exercise 10 min	30 min
0:40	2 · The user journey	Exercise 8 min	20 min
1:00	3 · What do we build first? Planning the MVP	Exercise 15 min	35 min
1:35	Break		15 min
1:50	4 · Is it feasible? An initial check	Exercise 8 min	30 min
2:20	5 · Planning the prototype and its test	Exercise 10 min	30 min
2:50	6 · Roadmap, then the final exercise: MVP & Prototype Plan	Exercise 30 min	40 min
3:30	Team presentations and wrap-up		15 min

Session map

Six modules, six outputs, one page

Each module ends with a short exercise and one output. The six outputs fill the one-page plan you leave with.

1 · Value proposition	Job statement · VPC draft · riskiest assumption (RAT)	Plan § 1 · 4 · 5
2 · User journey	User story map (5–7 steps) · the critical moment · your MVP slice	Plan § 2 · 3
3 · Planning the MVP	MoSCoW triage · MVP type · success/stop criteria → MVP Canvas	Plan § 6 · 9
4 · Initial feasibility	Feasibility scorecard · build / buy / by-hand list	Plan § 7
5 · Prototype and test	Prototype plan (six decisions) · one stumble found in a paper test	Plan § 8
6 · Roadmap and plan	Four-week roadmap · one-page plan, reviewed by another team	Plan § 10 + review

Every exercise says what it produces. Output lines on module slides are the checklist; the template at the end is where they land.

MODULE 1

From problem to value proposition

01

30 min · Exercise 10 min · Builds on sessions 1–2

- What job is the user hiring us to do?
- Does our solution fit their pains and gains?
- Which assumption, if wrong, kills the idea?

Output: Job statement · Value Proposition Canvas draft · riskiest assumption

Jobs to be Done

People don't buy apps. They "hire" a solution to get a job done

Once you understand the job, you see your real competitors: a friend's referral, a WhatsApp group, the usual way.

When [situation], **I want to** [motivation], **so I can** [expected outcome].

Functional

The practical task: get it done fast and right the first time

Emotional

How they want to feel: safe, not cheated, in control

Social

How they want to be seen: responsible, smart, caring

EXAMPLE When my child is struggling before an exam, I want a tutor I can trust tonight, so I can stop worrying.

Value proposition: does your solution fit what users need?

A Stage 1 output. Fill the right side from your research first; only then design the left side to match it.

Your solution (value map)

Products & services
What you offer

Pain relievers
How it removes or reduces each pain

Gain creators
How it produces the gains they want

FIT

Your user (customer profile)

Jobs
What they are trying to get done

Pains
Frustrations, risks, obstacles

Gains
Outcomes and benefits they want

EXAMPLE Pain: "I don't know if a tutor is any good." → Reliever: verified tutor profiles with a free 10-minute trial call.

Case: Dabberli

Every product faces four kinds of risk

Test the riskiest first. Most technical teams start with feasibility because it is the most comfortable, not the most dangerous.

Usually riskiest

Value

Do they actually want it?
e.g. Will parents book a tutor online instead of asking friends?

Usability

Can they figure out how to use it?
e.g. Can a 60-year-old finish checkout alone?

Feasibility

Can we build it within our constraints?
e.g. Real-time matching on a flaky connection

Viability

Does it work as a business?
e.g. Does the commission cover the cost of serving each order?

Ask your team: which of the four have we tested, and which have we just assumed?

Case: Dabberli

Start with what matters most and is least proven

Example: tutoring marketplace

Importance

↑

High

Test first

- Parents will book online
- Parents trust a stranger

Monitor

- Tutors show up on time

Test later

- Parents pay in advance

Ignore for now

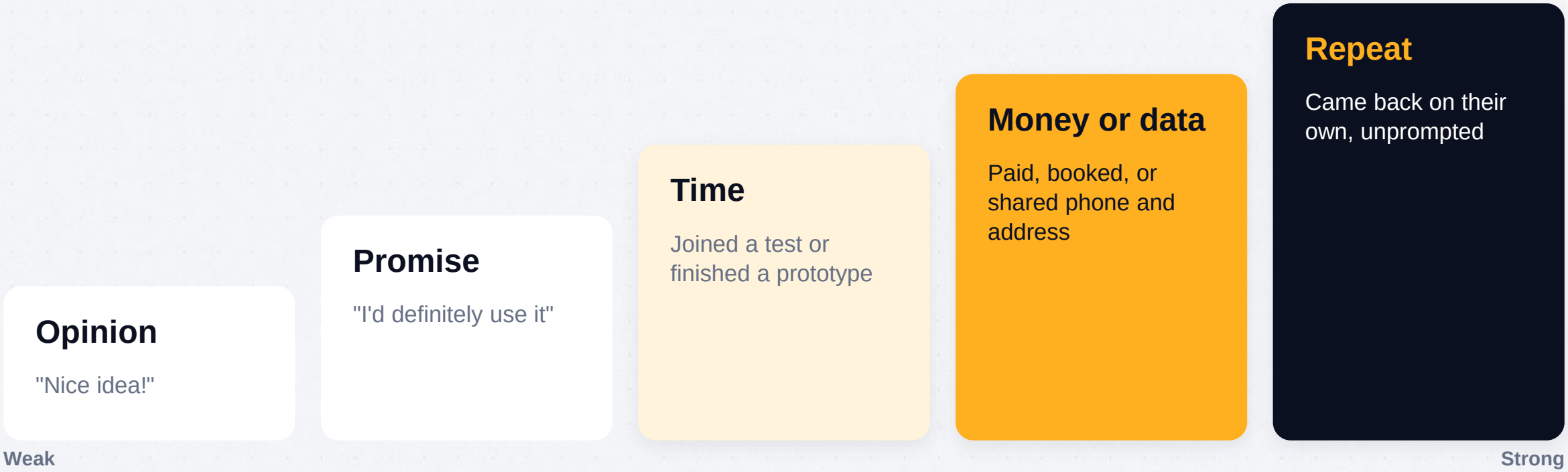
Low

Little evidence → Strong evidence

Evidence ladder

The closer to commitment, the stronger the evidence

Place every signal you hear on this ladder. Anything below "Time" is not evidence yet.



EXERCISE · 10 min

Exercise 1 · Job, value proposition, riskiest assumption

1	Restate your problem definition as a job: "When…, I want to…, so I can…"	2 min
2	Draft your Value Proposition Canvas: top 3 pains and gains, and how you relieve or create each	4 min
3	List five assumptions behind the fit; tag each by risk type; circle the riskiest on the map	2 min
4	Write what evidence would prove it, using the evidence ladder	2 min

Output: Job statement + Value Proposition Canvas draft + your riskiest assumption (RAT)

MODULE 2

The user journey

20 min · Exercise 8 min · Uses your personas

02

- How does the user get the job done today, step by step?
- Where does the usual way break down?
- Which single moment must our solution win?

Output: User story map · the critical moment · your MVP slice

Case: Dabberli

Walk the journey before you draw the screen

Map how the user does the job today, with the usual way. One step decides everything.

Example: tutoring marketplace

1 Trigger	2 Search	3 Choose	4 Agree	5 Session	6 After
DOES Child fails a quiz; the exam is in 3 days	**DOES** Asks friends and two WhatsApp groups	**DOES** Picks whoever replies first	**DOES** Calls, haggles over price and time	**DOES** Tutor comes over, or a video call	**DOES** Pays cash; maybe keeps the number
FEELS Worried	**FEELS** Unsure	**FEELS** Doubtful	**FEELS** Awkward	**FEELS** Relieved, or regretful	**FEELS** Done, for now
PAIN **No time to search properly**	**PAIN** **Random names, nothing to compare**	**PAIN** **Can't tell if the tutor is any good**	**PAIN** **Price unclear until the call**	**PAIN** **Quality varies; no backup**	**PAIN** **Nothing to reuse next time**

CRITICAL MOMENT Step 3, choosing: trust decides whether they book at all. That step becomes your key screen (Exercise 5) and the task your testers get (Module 5).

Story map: under each step, write what your solution does there. The thinnest slice that still wins the critical moment is your MVP; the rest stays manual.

EXERCISE · 8 min

Exercise 2 · Map the user journey

1	List 5 to 7 steps of how your persona gets the job done today, with the usual way	2 min
2	For each step, write what they do, what they feel, and the pain	3 min
3	Circle the critical moment: the step where your solution must win	1 min
4	Under each step, write what your solution does; the thinnest slice that wins the critical moment is your MVP	2 min

Output: User story map (5–7 steps) + the critical moment + your MVP slice, which becomes the key screen and the prototype task

MODULE 3

What do we build first? Planning the MVP

03

35 min · Exercise 15 min

- What's the cheapest experiment that answers the riskiest question?
- How do we cut scope without losing the question?
- Which number decides: continue or stop?

Output: MoSCoW triage · MVP type · success and stop criteria · MVP Canvas

Concepts

Prototype, MVP, product: three different things

Mixing them up is why so many "MVPs" take a full year.



Prototype

Shows the idea and tests understanding and usability. Nothing may work behind it.

Do they understand it?



MVP

The simplest real version that tests your riskiest assumption with real users.

Do they want it? Do they come back?



Product

Serves the market continuously and scales. Comes after evidence, not before.

Can it handle growth?



An MVP is not a small product. It's the cheapest experiment that answers your riskiest question (a Riskiest Assumption Test).

Case: Dabberli

Not every MVP is code: six types, cheapest first

Start here: cheapest and fastest

Most expensive and slowest

1 Hours

Fake door

A "Book now" button that leads to a waitlist

Do they care?

2 A day

AI-generated prototype

Clickable screens generated in an afternoon

Do they get it?

3 Days

Concierge

You personally deliver the service via WhatsApp

Do they want it?

4 A week

Wizard of Oz

Real app front-end, humans doing the work behind it

Do operations work?

5 Weeks

Single-feature product

Only the one feature that delivers the core value

Do they come back?

6 Months

Scalable product

Automation, integrations, performance

Does it hold at volume?

Fix the time. Let the scope flex

Decide your "appetite" for the problem first, then shape the solution to fit it. Never the other way round.

Appetite first

- ✓ Set the time first: two weeks
- ✓ Ask: what's the smallest solution that tests the bet?
- ✓ Cut scope until it fits the time
- ✓ Not done in time? Rethink, don't extend

The usual way

- ✗ List every feature upfront
- ✗ Estimate: eight months
- ✗ It stretches to fourteen
- ✗ Launch late, with no evidence

Now · After evidence · Maybe never

Our MoSCoW: Now = Must · After evidence = Should and Could · Maybe never = Won't, until evidence says otherwise

Now

Tests the riskiest bet

- **Place an order**
- **Confirm by phone or message**
- **Track orders manually**

After evidence

Built only if demand is proven

- Ratings and reviews
- Scheduled bookings
- Online payment

Maybe never

Until proven otherwise

- Native iOS and Android apps
- Wallet and loyalty points
- AI chatbot for everything

"Later" is not a promise. It's a decision that depends on what we learn.

Write success and stop criteria before you start

This completes your Test Card: hypothesis (RAT) · test (MVP) · metric · criteria. Decide it in advance.

The bet holds if **[measurable behavior]** from **[number or segment]** within **[time]**. We stop if **[minimum threshold]**

Continue if	20 strangers sign up for a class within 2 weeks and 5 come back for a second one
Adjust if	Sign-ups come but nobody returns: the problem is the experience, not the need
Stop if	Fewer than 6 sign-ups in 2 weeks despite reaching 500 people

Example: an online cooking class, illustrative numbers

Case: Dabberli

The MVP Canvas: your MVP on one page

Seven blocks, each filled by an exercise you did today. Copy them in; invent nothing.

Example: tutoring marketplace

Segmented persona
Sessions 1–2

Who tries it first? One persona, not a market

Persona A: parent of a 9th-grader, exam within days, trusts referrals

MVP proposal
Module 3

What is the MVP, for whom, in which form (the MVP ladder)?

Concierge via WhatsApp: a parent sends a request, we match a verified tutor by hand within 2 hours

Features (Must)
Module 3

Only the Now / Must bucket: 3 to 4 features

Request form · verified tutor profiles · confirmation call before the session

Journey
Module 2

Which steps the MVP touches; the rest stays manual

Steps 2 to 4: search, choose, agree. Session and payment unchanged

Expected outcome
Module 1

The riskiest assumption (RAT) this MVP must confirm

Parents will book a stranger through us instead of asking friends

Metrics
Module 3

The number that decides continue, adjust, or stop

20 bookings in 2 weeks and 5 repeats · stop below 6 from 500 reached

Cost and schedule
Modules 3–4

Appetite in weeks, people, and what running it by hand costs

2 weeks · 1 coordinator + 1 developer · WhatsApp Business, a form and a sheet: no custom code yet

EXERCISE · 15 min

Exercise 3 · Define your MVP

1	Set your appetite in weeks, then list every feature you dreamed of	3 min
2	Sort: Now (Must) · After evidence (Should, Could) · Maybe never (Won't); only 3 to 4 in Now	4 min
3	Pick the cheapest MVP type from the ladder that answers your question	3 min
4	Write your success and stop criteria, then fill the MVP Canvas (previous slide)	5 min

Output: MoSCoW triage + MVP type + success and stop criteria = your MVP Canvas



Break · 15 minutes

Up next: is it feasible? An initial check

MODULE 4

Is it feasible? An initial check

04

30 min · Exercise 8 min · Stage 1 output

- Can we build it, run it, and afford it?
- How do our constraints shape the solution?
- Where does AI genuinely add value?

Output: Feasibility scorecard · build / buy / by-hand list

Four lenses for an initial feasibility check

Stage 1 asks one thing: are there deal-breakers? The detailed technical plan comes in Stage 2.

Technical

Can we build a first version with our skills, tools and time?
e.g. Does the team know the core technology?

Operational

Can we deliver it every day, not just once?
e.g. Who handles no-shows and support?

Financial

Does one unit make money? Can we fund the MVP?
e.g. Does the fee cover the cost of serving?

Legal & ethical

Is it allowed, safe, and respectful of user data?
e.g. Minors, payments, personal data

Initial, not final: you're looking for showstoppers and open questions, not a full engineering plan.

Our reality

Constraints are not excuses. They are design inputs

Name your real constraints now, so the solution you plan is one you can actually deliver.

Unstable internet	Plan for offline use and a fallback channel (message or call)
Power cuts	No server in the office: plan for cloud hosting
Payment limits	Start with cash or local transfer; online payment only after demand is proven
User trust	Verified identity, upfront prices, a confirmation call
Skills and budget	Mainstream, ready-made tools before custom building

Case: Dabberli

Build only what sets you apart. Do the rest by hand at first

Build

What makes you different
e.g. your matching logic, your unique experience

Buy / use

What's already solved
e.g. forms, messaging, login, hosting

Do it by hand

What demand hasn't proven yet
e.g. matching, scheduling, early support

How any process matures, from Stage 1 to later

1

Manual

A person does it and learns every case

2

AI-assisted

AI suggests, a human approves

3

Automated

Once the cases and exceptions are known

Does a single unit make money? Work it out on a napkin

If every order loses money, growth multiplies the loss. Scaling doesn't fix broken unit economics.

$3.0

Commission: 15% of a $20 order

−

$0.9

Operations: matching and confirmation call

−

$0.3

Incentives and discounts

=

$1.8

Contribution per order

Acquisition cost

What does it cost to win a customer? Recover it within a few orders

Orders per customer

Repeat behavior is what makes the math work

Leakage risk

If customer and provider deal directly, your fee disappears

Where AI fits

Three places AI can add value to your solution

For Stage 1, decide where AI adds real value. How to engineer it is a Stage 2 question.

Low risk

In building

Prototypes, screens and starter code in hours. The biggest speed-up, with the least risk.

Low risk

In operations

A copilot for your team: suggests matches, summarizes requests, drafts replies. A human approves.

After evidence

In the product

A feature users see directly. Needs testing, monitoring and a known cost per use.

Feasibility test for any AI idea: what happens when it's wrong? If the answer is "a human catches it", it's feasible today.

Feasibility scorecard

Your initial feasibility assessment, on one table

One rating, one piece of evidence and one open question per lens. Amber is fine; hidden red is not.

Lens	Rating	Evidence we have	Open question
Technical	Green	Team has built booking apps before	Video calls on weak connections?
Operational	Amber	3 tutors agreed to pilot	Who handles no-shows?
Financial	Amber	15% fee covers about $1 per session	Will parents pay upfront?
Legal & ethical	Green	Only contact details are stored	Child-safety policy for sessions

Example: tutoring marketplace

EXERCISE · 8 min

Exercise 4 · Initial feasibility check

1	List your solution's main components; tag each: build · buy · by hand	2 min
2	Rate the four lenses Green, Amber or Red, with one piece of evidence each	3 min
3	Do the napkin math for one unit (one order, session or visit)	2 min
4	Name your biggest possible deal-breaker, and how you'll check it	1 min

Output: Your initial feasibility assessment: a scorecard + a build / buy / by-hand list

MODULE 5

Planning the prototype and its test

05

30 min · Exercise 10 min · Low-fidelity first

- → Which question must the prototype answer?
- → Who tests it, and doing what?
- → What result means go, adjust, or stop?

Output: Prototype plan (six decisions) · one stumble from a paper test

Your question decides the type of prototype

Do users understand the idea?	Paper sketch, or a clickable AI-generated prototype built in hours
Do they want the service?	A landing page with a real sign-up button (fake door), measuring clicks
Can we actually deliver it?	Deliver it by hand to a few users: concierge or Wizard of Oz
Will they pay?	A pre-order or a small real payment, never "how much would you pay?"

Case: Dabberli

A prototype plan fits on one page: six decisions

Stage 1 plans a low-fidelity prototype. Stage 2 starts building from this plan, so decide it now, while changing it is still cheap.

1

The question

The one thing this prototype must answer

2

Type and fidelity

Low-fi first: paper or clickable screens

3

Who tests it

Picked from your personas; 5 per round

4

The task

What they will try to do, in their words

5

The signal

What we watch, and the bar for success

6

What it takes

Time, tools, people, and lab needs if any

EXAMPLE Can parents book a trial lesson alone? · Clickable prototype · 5 parents from persona A · Success: 4 of 5 finish unaided

How the test will run: four rules to plan for now

You'll run it in Stage 2, but agree on how now, so the result is evidence and not opinion.

1

Give a task

"Book a tutor for tomorrow", not a tour of the idea

2

Watch in silence

Their struggle is the data. Don't rescue them

3

Ask "why?"

After the action, not before

4

Log behavior

What they did, not what they said

Plan what you'll measure, and what each result will mean

Clarity
Did they finish the task alone?

Desire
Did they ask to use it again?

Commitment
Did they sign up, book, or pay?

Cost
What did delivering it cost us?

Decide now what each result will trigger

Persevere
Above the success bar: expand by one step

Pivot
Real problem, but change the solution, segment or channel

Stop
Below the stop bar: free the time for a better idea

EXERCISE · 10 min

Exercise 5 · Paper test of your key screen

1	Sketch the screen for the critical moment of your journey map (paper or an AI tool)	2 min
2	A teammate tries a specific task while you stay completely silent	3 min
3	Swap roles	4 min
4	Write down the biggest stumble, and what it changes in your plan	1 min

Output: One documented stumble per person, and one change to your prototype plan

MODULE 6

Bring it together: roadmap and plan

06

Roadmap 10 min · Exercise 30 min · Presentations 15 min

- What happens in each of the four weeks of Stage 2?
- Put today's work on one page
- Review it with another team

Output: Four-week roadmap · one-page MVP & Prototype Plan

Four weeks from plan to tested prototype

Stage 2 runs Oct 29 to Nov 28. Fix the weeks, flex the scope: one owner and one deliverable per week.

Week 1 · Oct 29 – Nov 4

Build the prototype

- Sketch or generate the screens for your critical moment
- Set up the bought and manual pieces: form, WhatsApp, sheet
- Recruit 5 testers from your persona

Milestone: Prototype ready for a user

Week 2 · Nov 5 – 11

Test round 1

- 5 sessions: give the task, watch in silence, log behavior
- Compare what happened with your success bar
- List the three biggest stumbles

Milestone: First evidence, and a fix list

Week 3 · Nov 12 – 18

Fix, then run it live

- Fix the stumbles; build only the "Now" features
- Run the MVP by hand with real users
- Count real actions, not opinions

Milestone: MVP live, by hand

Week 4 · Nov 19 – 28

Round 2, then decide

- Second round with 5 new users
- Measure against success and stop criteria
- Decide: persevere, pivot, or stop

Milestone: Decision, and your Stage 2 presentation

Each week has one owner and one deliverable you can show. Mentor and lab time goes into the week it serves: book it in week 1, not when you get stuck.

EXERCISE · 30 min

Final exercise · MVP & Prototype Plan

1	Fill in all ten sections of the plan (next slide); the roadmap is section 10	20 min
2	Swap plans with another team and review	10 min
3	Ask: Is the value clear? What's the riskiest assumption? Any deal-breakers?	

Output: One page that completes your Stage 1 outputs and hands Stage 2 a clear plan

Template

The MVP & Prototype Plan: ten sections on one page

1

Problem and job

When… I want to… so I can…

2

User and persona

Who exactly, from sessions 1–2

3

User journey

5–7 steps and the critical moment

4

Value proposition fit

Top pains and gains, and your answer

5

Riskiest assumption

And which of the four risks

6

MVP type and "Now" features

MVP Canvas: type, Must features, appetite

7

Initial feasibility

Scorecard: four lenses

8

Prototype plan

Question, type, testers, task

9

Success and stop criteria

What each result will trigger

10

Four-week roadmap

One owner and one deliverable per week

Six rules to take with you

01 Start with the job, not the solution

02 Fit before features

03 Walk the journey before you draw the screen

04 An MVP is a question, not a small product

05 Fix the time, flex the scope

06 Plan the test, and the four weeks, before you build

Before the checkpoint

Your Stage 1 outputs: complete them from today's plan

Stage 1 outputs and evaluation point, from the participant handbook.

Stage 1 outputs

- Clear problem definition and why you chose it
- Stakeholder map and user personas
- Initial feasibility assessment of your solution
- Value Proposition Canvas

What the checkpoint looks at

- Your understanding of the problem
- The clarity of your proposed solution
- Its potential for technical development

Next: Stage 2 (Oct 29 – Nov 28) follows your four-week roadmap to a working, tested prototype.

Thank you

Mhd Tarek Almalek

Tech entrepreneur · Digital transformation advisor · AI specialist

Runs **IXCoders** · **Tamkeen**


linkedin.com/in/mhd-tarek-almalek


facebook.com/Mhd.Tarek.Almalek


instagram.com/mhdtarekalmalek